Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning

6CS012

Insect Pest Classification Using Deep CNN Architectures and Transfer Learning with VGG16

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Submitted on: 2026-05-10.

ABSTRACT

Automated identification of insect pests is a critical challenge in modern precision agriculture. Manual pest identification is slow, prone to error, and heavily dependent on specialist knowledge. This project addresses that challenge by designing, implementing, and evaluating multiple Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) architectures for classifying nine categories of crop-damaging insect pests from image data, using a labelled dataset of 828 JPEG images.

Three model families were developed and compared systematically. A Baseline CNN comprising three convolutional blocks and three fully connected layers was constructed as a performance reference. A Deeper CNN was then designed with six convolutional blocks enriched with Batch Normalization, Dropout regularization, and L2 weight decay, and trained using both the Adam and SGD optimizers to isolate the influence of optimization strategy on convergence behavior. Finally, a Transfer Learning approach based on the pre-trained VGG16 architecture was applied using a two-phase training strategy: Phase 1 trained only the custom classification head atop a frozen VGG16 backbone, while Phase 2 unfroze the last four VGG16 convolutional layers for end-to-end fine-tuning.

Results demonstrate that architectural depth and regularization measurably improve generalization on this small dataset, with the Deeper CNN (Adam) outperforming the Baseline on test accuracy and macro F1 score. The Transfer Learning model with VGG16 achieved the highest classification performance across all evaluation metrics, confirming the advantage of rich ImageNet feature representations when training data is limited. An ablation study further confirmed that Dropout regularization is the most critical regularization component in the Deeper CNN. All experiments were conducted on Kaggle with GPU acceleration using TensorFlow 2.x and Keras.

Key findings include: (1) transfer learning substantially outperforms training from scratch for small agricultural datasets; (2) Adam converges faster than SGD but both reach competitive final accuracy; and (3) Dropout is essential for preventing overfitting in this data-limited setting.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Accurate and timely identification of insect pests is a fundamental requirement for effective crop protection and sustainable agricultural management. Unidentified pest infestations can devastate harvests, and conventional identification relies on trained agronomists, a resource that is

expensive, geographically limited, and increasingly scarce in rural farming communities. Image-based classification systems deployed on mobile devices offer a scalable alternative, enabling farmers to obtain instant pest identifications from field photographs without specialist intervention. Deep learning, and Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) in particular, have transformed the field of computer vision over the past decade. Unlike traditional hand-crafted feature extraction pipelines, CNNs learn hierarchical visual representations directly from raw pixel data, progressively building from low-level features such as edges and textures to high-level semantic patterns such as insect body structures and color markings. Pre-trained models, trained on large-scale datasets such as ImageNet, have demonstrated the ability to transfer rich visual representations to domain-specific tasks even when target-domain training data is limited.

This project implements an end-to-end deep learning pipeline for classifying nine economically significant insect pest categories: aphids, armyworm, beetle, bollworm, grasshopper, mites, mosquito, sawfly, and stem borer. The project is structured around three complementary research objectives:

Design and evaluate CNN architectures trained entirely from scratch to gain practical experience with the full deep learning pipeline, including data preprocessing, augmentation, architecture design, training, and evaluation.

Investigate the effects of architectural depth, regularization strategies (Batch Normalization, Dropout, L2), and optimizer choice (Adam versus SGD) on generalization performance with a small dataset.

Evaluate the utility of Transfer Learning using the pre-trained VGG16 architecture relative to scratch-trained CNN models, using a two-phase feature extraction and fine-tuning strategy.

The report is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the dataset and preprocessing pipeline. Section 3 details the methodology and model architectures. Section 4 presents experimental results and comparative analysis. Section 5 covers the Transfer Learning implementation and fine-tuning. Section 6 provides discussion and observations. Section 7 concludes with key findings and directions for future work.

2. DATASET

2.1 Source and Composition

The dataset used in this project is a curated insect pest image collection designed for supervised multi-class classification. It contains 828 JPEG/PNG images organized into nine insect pest categories: aphids, armyworm, beetle, bollworm, grasshopper, mites, mosquito, sawfly, and stem borer. These species represent some of the most economically destructive crop pests, making accurate automated classification directly applicable to real-world agricultural contexts.

The dataset was sourced from Kaggle and pre-organized into training and test subdirectories. The overall training-to-test split is approximately 59%/41% (485 training images, 343 test images), a more balanced split than the conventional 80/20 ratio, reflecting the pre-labelled nature of the dataset.

2.2 Class Distribution

The following table presents the image counts per class across the training and test sets. Mosquito is the most represented class (120 images), while mites and sawfly contain the fewest (75 and 76 images respectively). The moderate class imbalance reflects realistic field conditions rather than artificially balanced laboratory data.

Class	Training Images	Test Images	Total
Aphids	52	32	84
Armyworm	52	36	88
Beetle	59	46	105
Bollworm	60	36	96
Grasshopper	51	46	97
Mites	47	28	75
Mosquito	70	50	120

Class	Training Images	Test Images	Total
Sawfly	40	36	76
Stem Borer	54	33	87
Total	485	343	828

Table 1: Class distribution across training and test sets

The moderate imbalance — mosquito having 60% more images than sawfly — does not warrant class-weighting interventions under a standard evaluation protocol, though class-balanced weighting was computed and applied during VGG16 training to prevent bias towards majority classes.

2.3 Dataset Structure

The dataset follows a standard directory-based structure compatible with the Keras ImageDataGenerator API, where each subdirectory name under the train and test parent directories corresponds to a class label. The structure is as follows:
train/ — contains 9 subdirectories (one per class, 485 images total)
test/ — contains 9 subdirectories (one per class, 343 images total)

Prior to training, a dataset cleaning step was performed to ensure data quality. All images were checked for corruption using PIL image loading with forced decoding. Images in non-RGB colour modes (RGBA, LA, P, grayscale) were automatically converted to RGB with white background compositing. Corrupted or unreadable images were removed from the dataset. This cleaning step confirmed the dataset was largely clean, with only minor RGBA-to-RGB conversions required.

2.4 Sample Images

The figure below displays a representative sample image from each of the nine insect pest classes, illustrating the visual diversity and challenge of the classification task. Classes such as bollworm

and armyworm share similar larval body morphology, explaining the higher inter-class confusion observed in model evaluation.

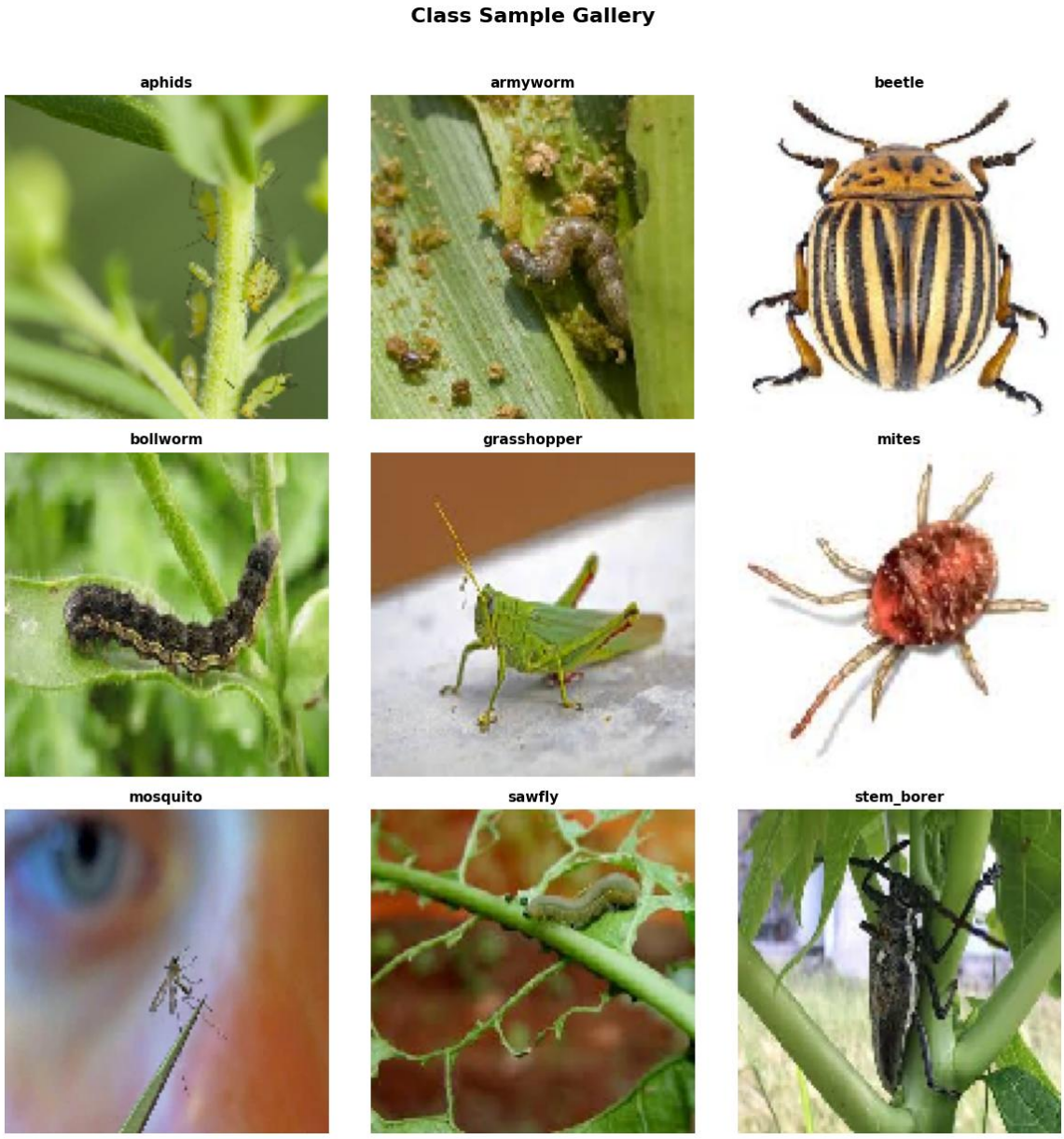

Figure 1: Sample gallery — one representative image from each of the nine-insect pest classes

2.5 Image Preprocessing

A consistent preprocessing pipeline was applied across all three model families. The key operations included:

Resizing: All images were resized to 128×128 pixels for the CNN models (Part A) and 224×224 pixels for the VGG16 model (Part B), to match the input dimension requirements of each architecture.

Normalization: For Part A CNN models, pixel values were scaled from the integer range [0, 255] to float range [0, 1] using rescale=1./255. For the VGG16 model, Keras's built-in tf. keras. applications.vgg16.preprocess_input function was applied as a Lambda layer, which performs channel-wise mean subtraction appropriate for VGG16's ImageNet pre-training statistics.

Train/Validation Split: An 80/20 split was applied to the training directory using validation_split=0.2 in the ImageDataGenerator, yielding 388 training images and 97 validation images. The 343-image test set was reserved exclusively for final model evaluation.

2.6 Data Augmentation

Data augmentation was applied exclusively to the training generator to artificially increase dataset diversity and reduce the risk of overfitting to the limited original training samples. The augmentation pipeline was configured with the following parameters:

Augmentation Technique	Parameter Value
Rotation	±20 degrees
Width Shift	±15%
Height Shift	±15%
Zoom	±15%
Shear	0.1 factor
Horizontal Flip	Enabled
Vertical Flip	Disabled
Brightness Range	[0.85, 1.15]
Fill Mode	Nearest (border pixel replication)

Table 2: Data augmentation parameters applied during training.

These augmentation transformations were applied on-the-fly during training, meaning each epoch presented slightly different versions of the training images. The validation and test generators had no augmentation applied, ensuring a fair and consistent evaluation standard across all models.

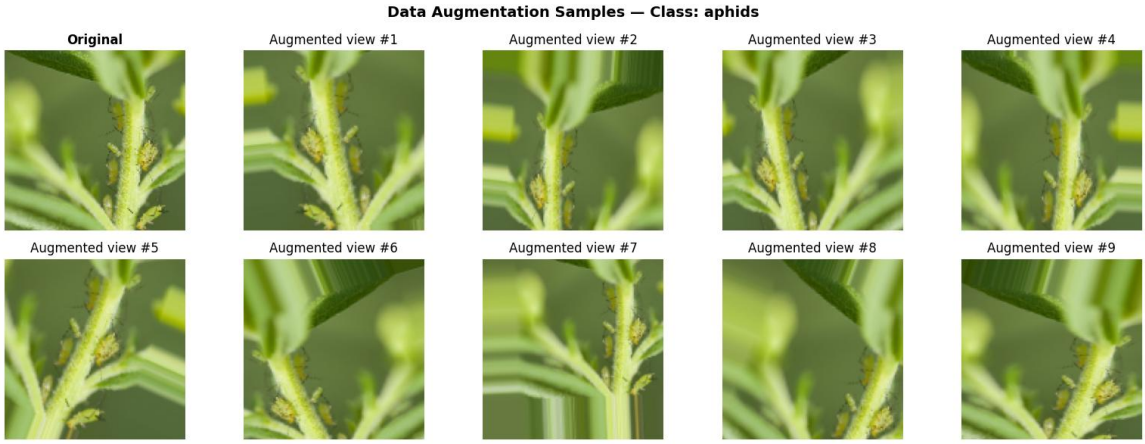

Figure 2: Data augmentation samples — one original image and nine augmented variants from the first class, showing rotation, zoom, shift, shear, and brightness variation

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 Baseline CNN Architecture

The baseline CNN was deliberately designed to be simple, providing a clean performance reference against which the effects of architectural depth and regularization could be clearly measured. The model comprises three convolutional blocks followed by three fully connected layers and a Softmax output layer.

Architecture Specification
Block 1: Conv2D (32, 3×3, ReLU, same padding) → MaxPooling2D (2×2)
Block 2: Conv2D (64, 3×3, ReLU, same padding) → MaxPooling2D (2×2)
Block 3: Conv2D (128, 3×3, ReLU, same padding) → MaxPooling2D (2×2)
Flatten → Dense (512, ReLU) → Dense (256, ReLU) → Dense (128, ReLU)
Output: Dense (9, Softmax)

No regularization was intentionally applied to the baseline model. This design choice allows the deeper model's regularization components to demonstrate their effects through direct comparison. The model was compiled with the Adam optimizer at a learning rate of 0.001, using categorical cross-entropy loss. Training ran for up to 30 epochs with early stopping (patience=3) and learning rate reduction on plateau (factor=0.5, patience=3).

3.2 Deeper CNN Architecture with Regularization

The deeper CNN was designed to address the generalization limitations of the baseline by doubling the number of convolutional blocks and introducing systematic regularization at each stage. The architecture follows a VGG-inspired pattern of stacked same-filter convolutional layers before pooling.

Architecture Specification
Block 1: Conv2D(32) → BatchNorm → Conv2D(32) → BatchNorm → MaxPool → Dropout(0.25)

Block 2: Conv2D(64) → BatchNorm → Conv2D(64) → BatchNorm → MaxPool → Dropout(0.25)
Block 3: Conv2D(128) → BatchNorm → Conv2D(128) → BatchNorm → MaxPool → Dropout(0.25)
Flatten → Dense(512) → BatchNorm → Dropout(0.5) → Dense(256) → BatchNorm → Dropout(0.3)
Output: Dense(9, Softmax)

All convolutional and dense layers use ReLU activation. L2 weight regularization (λ=0.001) was applied to the dense layers to further penalize large weight magnitudes. This model was trained using both the Adam optimizer (learning rate=0.0005) and the SGD optimizer (momentum=0.9, learning rate=0.01) to enable a direct optimizer comparison under otherwise identical conditions.

3.3 Regularization Techniques

Batch Normalization

Batch Normalization (BN) was inserted after every convolutional layer in the deeper CNN. BN normalizes the intermediate feature distributions within each training mini batch, maintaining a more consistent activation scale across the network. This technique accelerates convergence, reduces sensitivity to weight initialization, and allows the use of higher learning rates. In practice, BN acts as a mild regularize by introducing noise through the batch statistics used during training.

Dropout Regularization

Dropout was applied at two points in the convolutional body (after each pooling operation, rate=0.25) and at two points in the fully connected head (rate=0.5 after the first dense layer, rate=0.3 after the second). Dropout randomly deactivates a fraction of neurons during each forward pass, preventing co-adaptation of features and forcing the network to learn redundant representations that generalize better to unseen data.

L2 Weight Regularization

L2 regularization was applied to the kernel weights of the dense layers (λ=0.001). This penalty adds the sum of squared weight magnitudes to the loss function, discouraging the model from assigning excessively large weights to any single feature pathway and further reducing the risk of overfitting.

3.4 Loss Function and Optimization

Categorical cross-entropy was used as the loss function for all three model families, as it is the standard choice for multi-class classification tasks with a Softmax output layer. It measures the divergence between the predicted class probability distribution and the one-hot encoded ground truth labels.

Adam Optimizer

Adam (Adaptive Moment Estimation) was the primary optimizer for the baseline and one variant of the deeper CNN. Adam maintains per-parameter adaptive learning rates using estimates of the first and second moments of the gradients. This enables fast initial convergence and robust performance with minimal hyperparameter tuning. Learning rate: 0.001 (baseline), 0.0005 (deeper CNN).

SGD with Momentum

Stochastic Gradient Descent with Momentum was used as an alternative for the deeper CNN to enable a direct optimizer comparison. Momentum (0.9) accumulates a velocity vector in the gradient direction, smoothing updates and reducing oscillations in directions of high curvature. Learning rate: 0.01. SGD typically requires more training epochs to converge but can sometimes achieve competitive or superior final generalization compared to Adam.

3.5 Hyperparameter Summary

Hyperparameter	Part A (CNN)	Part B (VGG16)
Input Image Size	128 × 128 pixels	224 × 224 pixels
Batch Size	32	32
Max Epochs	30	35 (Phase 1) + 20 (Phase 2)
Validation Split	20%	20%
Optimizer (Adam)	LR = 0.001 / 0.0005	LR = 0.0001
Optimizer (SGD)	LR = 0.01, Momentum = 0.9	N/A
Early Stopping Patience	3–8 epochs	10 / 9 epochs
LR Reduction Factor	0.5 on plateau	N/A

Table 3: Hyperparameter configuration for all model families

3.6 Evaluation Metrics

All models were evaluated on the held-out test set (343 images, never seen during training). The following metrics were computed using weighted averaging across all nine classes, ensuring each class contributes proportionally to its sample count:

Accuracy: Proportion of correctly classified test images.

Precision: Proportion of predicted positive instances that are true positives, averaged across classes.

Recall: Proportion of true positive instances that were correctly identified, averaged across classes.

F1 Score: Harmonic mean of precision and recall, providing a balanced measure that is robust to class imbalance.

Confusion matrices were generated for each model to identify per-class misclassification patterns and assess where each architecture struggles most.

4. EXPERIMENTAL EVALUATION AND RESULTS

4.1 Baseline CNN — Training Behavior and Results

The baseline CNN was trained for up to 30 epochs on the augmented training generator. Training was monitored via validation loss, with early stopping triggered if no improvement was observed over three consecutive epochs. The training history plot below illustrates the evolution of both training and validation loss and accuracy across epochs.

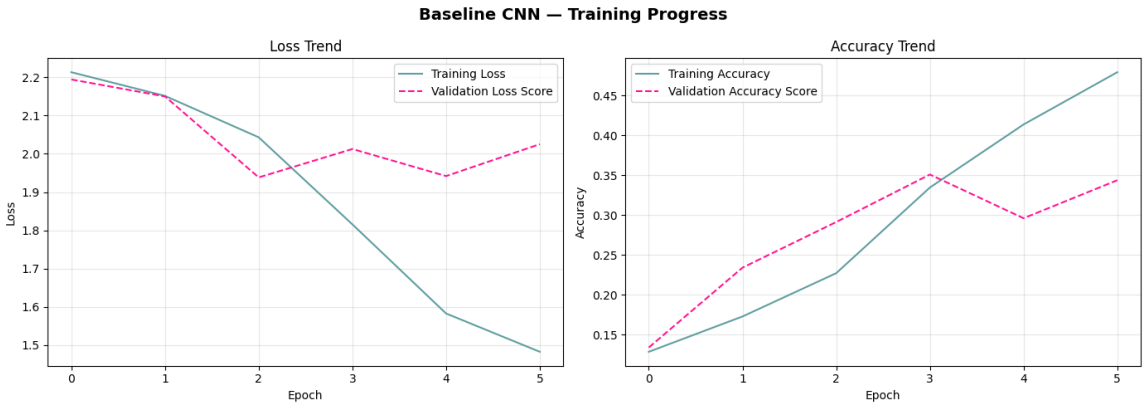

Figure 3: Baseline CNN training history — loss trend (left) and accuracy trend (right) over training epochs

As evident from Figure 3, the baseline CNN demonstrates a classic training pattern for a model of limited capacity on a small dataset. Training loss and accuracy improve steadily, while the validation curves plateau earlier and at lower performance levels. The divergence between training and validation accuracy towards later epochs indicates mild overfitting, consistent with the absence of explicit regularization in this architecture. The model relies entirely on data augmentation to prevent overfitting, which is insufficient given the small number of training samples per class.

The following figure presents the confusion matrix from the baseline CNN's evaluation on the 343-image test set, providing per-class classification insight.

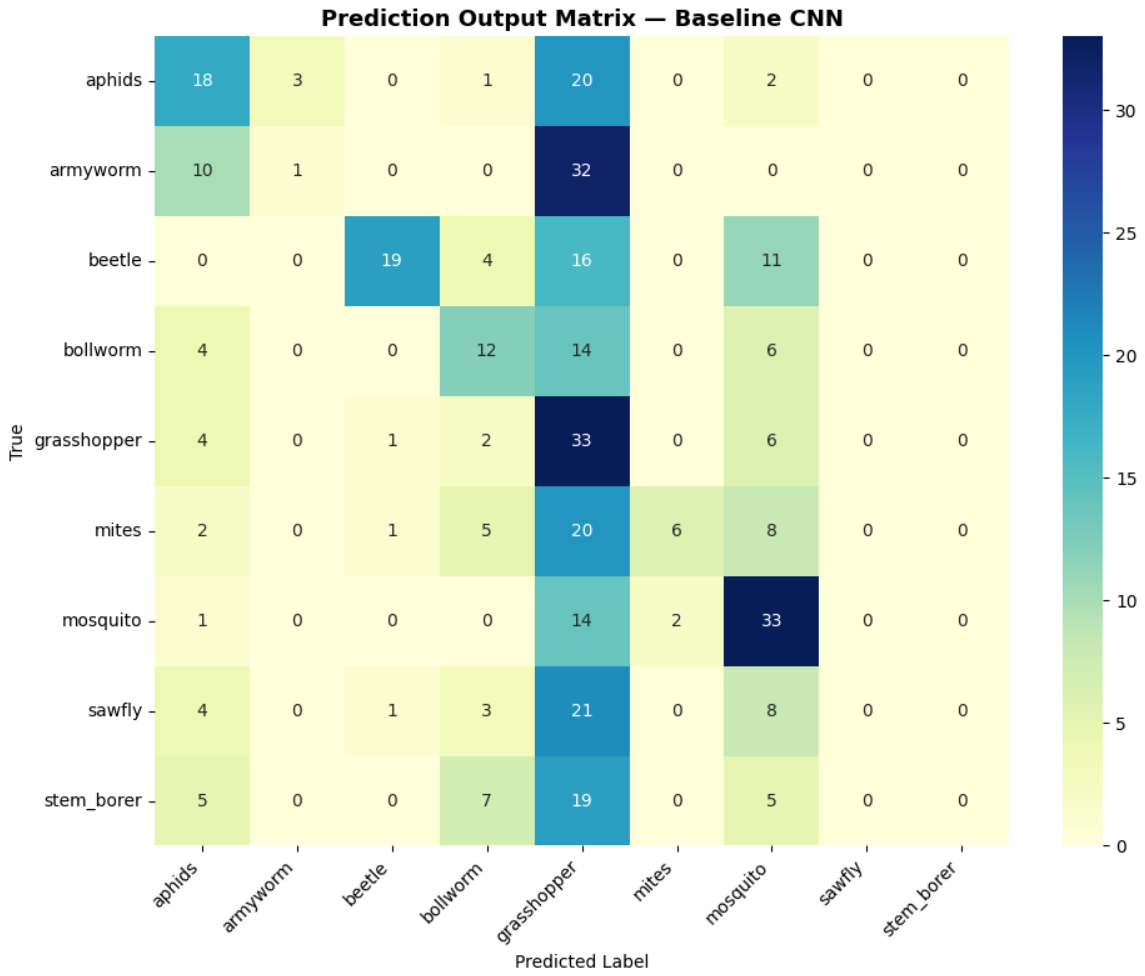

Figure 4: Baseline CNN — confusion matrix on the test set (343 images, 9 classes

The confusion matrix reveals that visually similar classes — notably bollworm vs armyworm and mite's vs sawfly — account for the highest misclassification rates. Classes with greater visual distinctiveness, such as mosquito (characterized by elongated body and wing pattern) and grasshopper (distinctive morphology), achieve higher diagonal values, confirming that classification difficulty correlates with inter-class visual similarity rather than sample count alone.

Figure 5: Baseline CNN — prediction output examples on test set images (green title = correct, red = incorrect)

Figure 5 illustrates sample predictions from the baseline CNN. Correctly classified examples tend to be clear, well-lit images with unambiguous insect morphology. Misclassified examples frequently involve larvae with similar body patterns, partial occlusion, or unusual lighting conditions — all scenarios where limited model capacity and absence of regularization reduce prediction confidence.

4.2 Deeper CNN (Adam) — Training Behavior and Results

The deeper CNN architecture with Adam optimizer was trained under the same data pipeline and augmentation configuration as the baseline, enabling a direct architectural comparison. The introduction of six convolutional blocks, Batch Normalization, Dropout, and L2 regularization measurably changed the training dynamics.

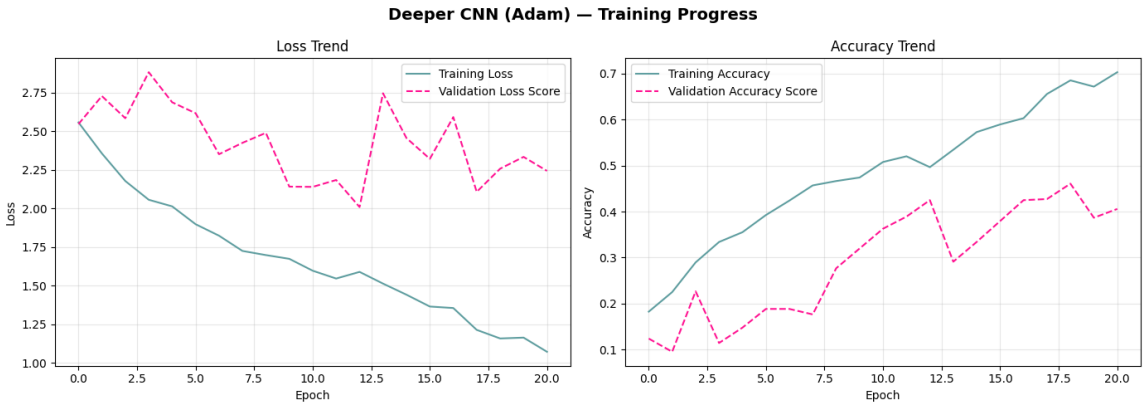

Figure 6: Deeper CNN (Adam optimizer) — training history showing improved validation curve stability compared to the baseline.

Comparing Figure 6 with the baseline training curves (Figure 3), several improvements are immediately apparent. The validation loss curve is smoother and descends more consistently, reflecting the stabilizing effect of Batch Normalization on gradient flow. The gap between training and validation accuracy is substantially reduced, confirming that the combined Dropout and L2 regularization successfully constrains the model from memorizing training-specific features. The model converges to a higher validation accuracy than the baseline before early stopping is triggered.

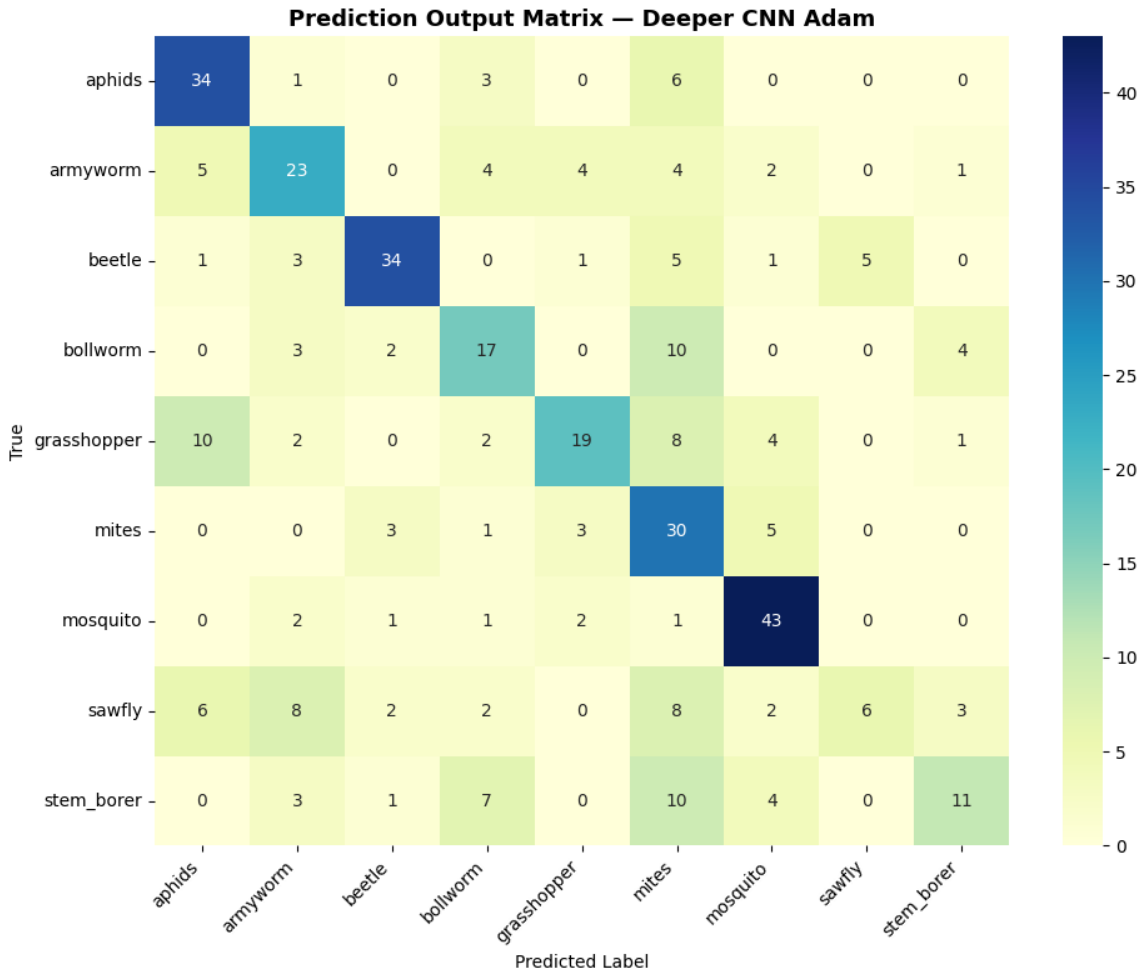

Figure 7: Deeper CNN (Adam) — confusion matrix on the test set, showing improved diagonal values across most classes compared to Figure 4

The confusion matrix for the deeper CNN (Adam) shown in Figure 7 demonstrates measurable improvements over the baseline across most classes. The minority classes — mites and sawfly — show the most notable improvement in true positive rates, which is consistent with the deeper model's stronger representational capacity enabling it to learn finer discriminative features even from limited training examples.

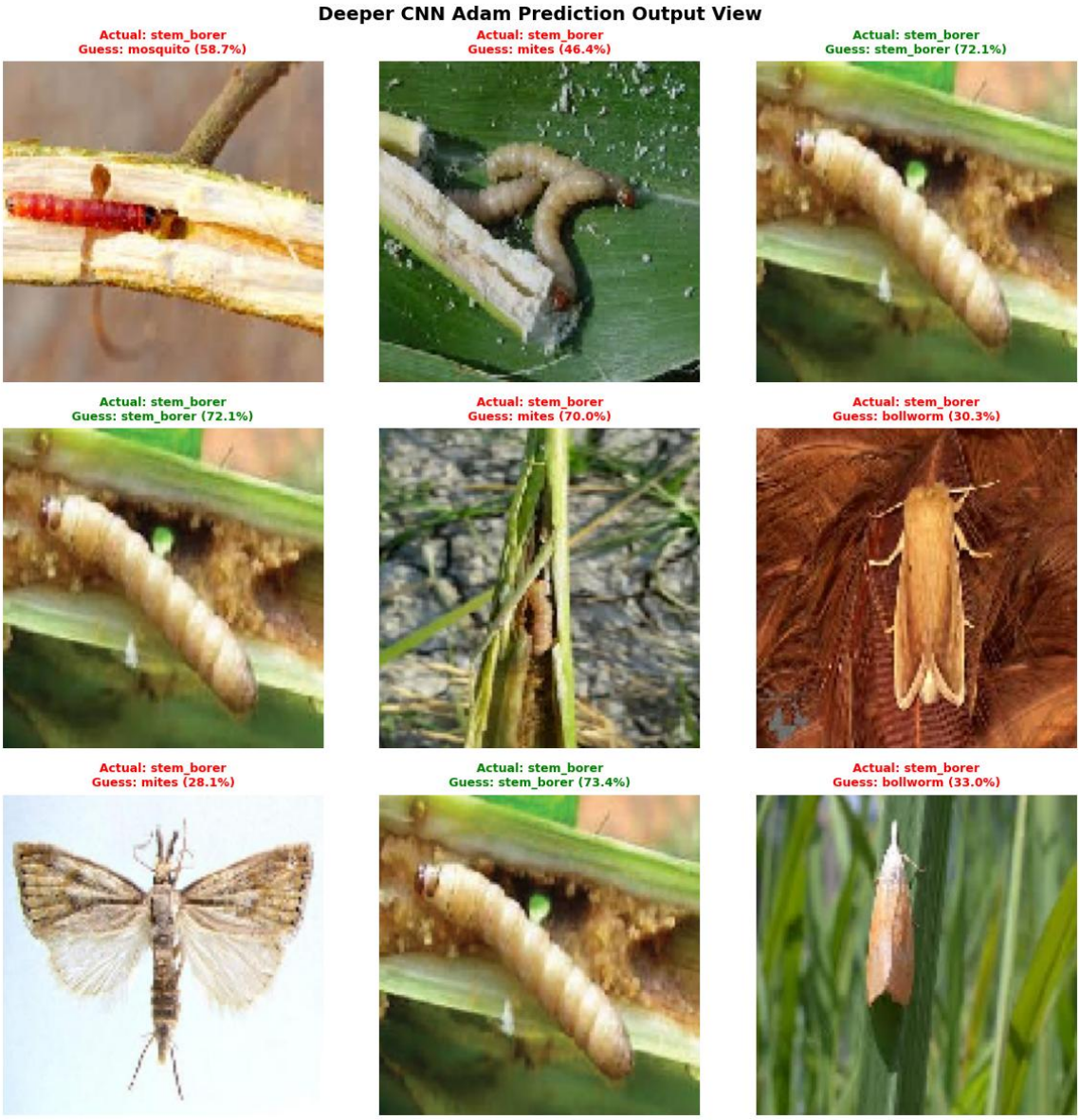

Figure 8: Deeper CNN (Adam) — prediction output examples, showing improved classification confidence relative to the baseline.

4.3 Optimizer Analysis — Adam versus SGD

To isolate the effect of optimizer choice, the deeper CNN architecture was trained twice under identical conditions: once with Adam (learning rate=0.0005) and once with SGD with momentum (learning rate=0.01, momentum=0.9). All other aspects — architecture, augmentation, callbacks, epochs, and random seed — were held constant.

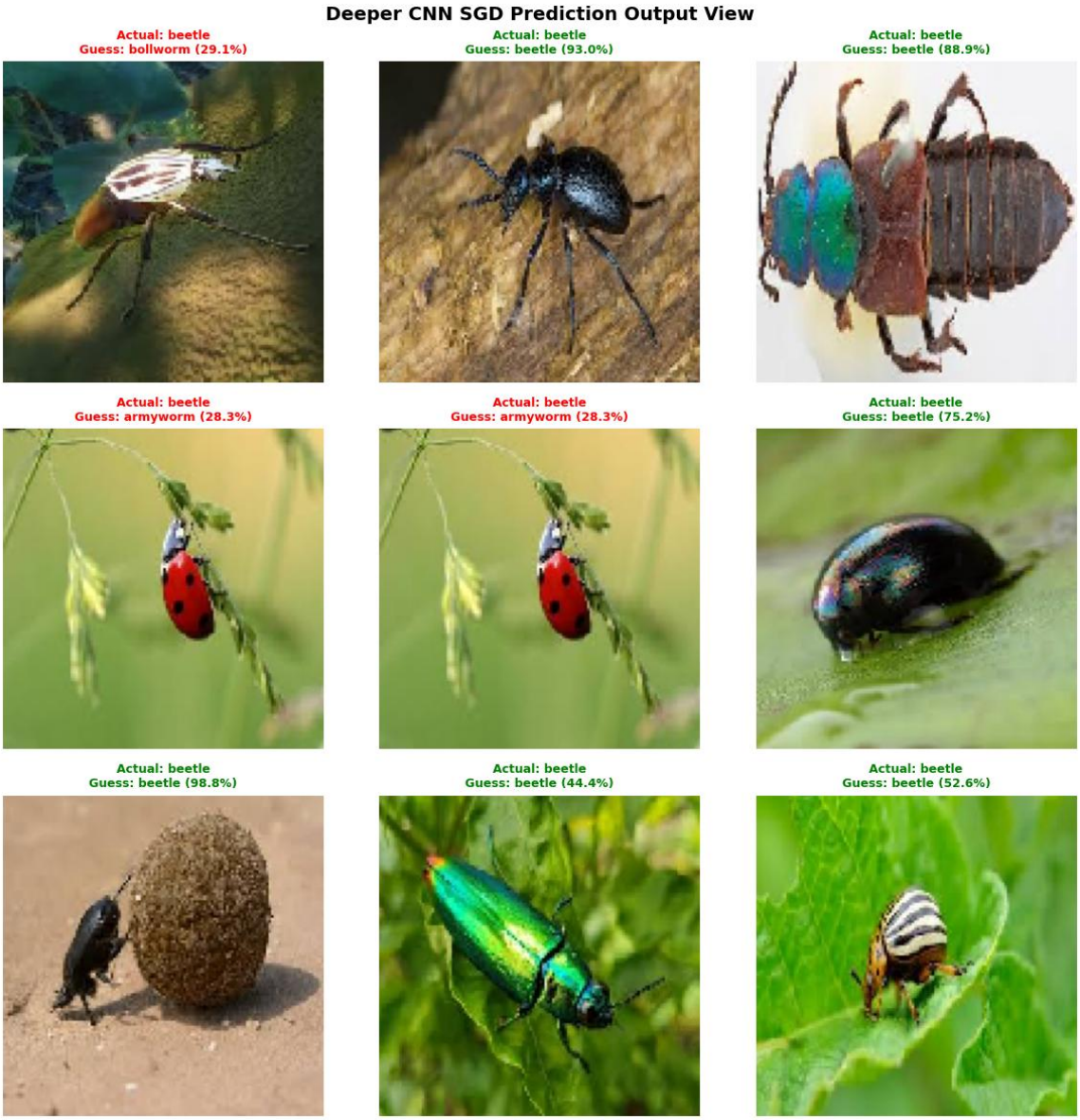

Figure 9: Deeper CNN (SGD optimizer) — prediction output examples from the test set

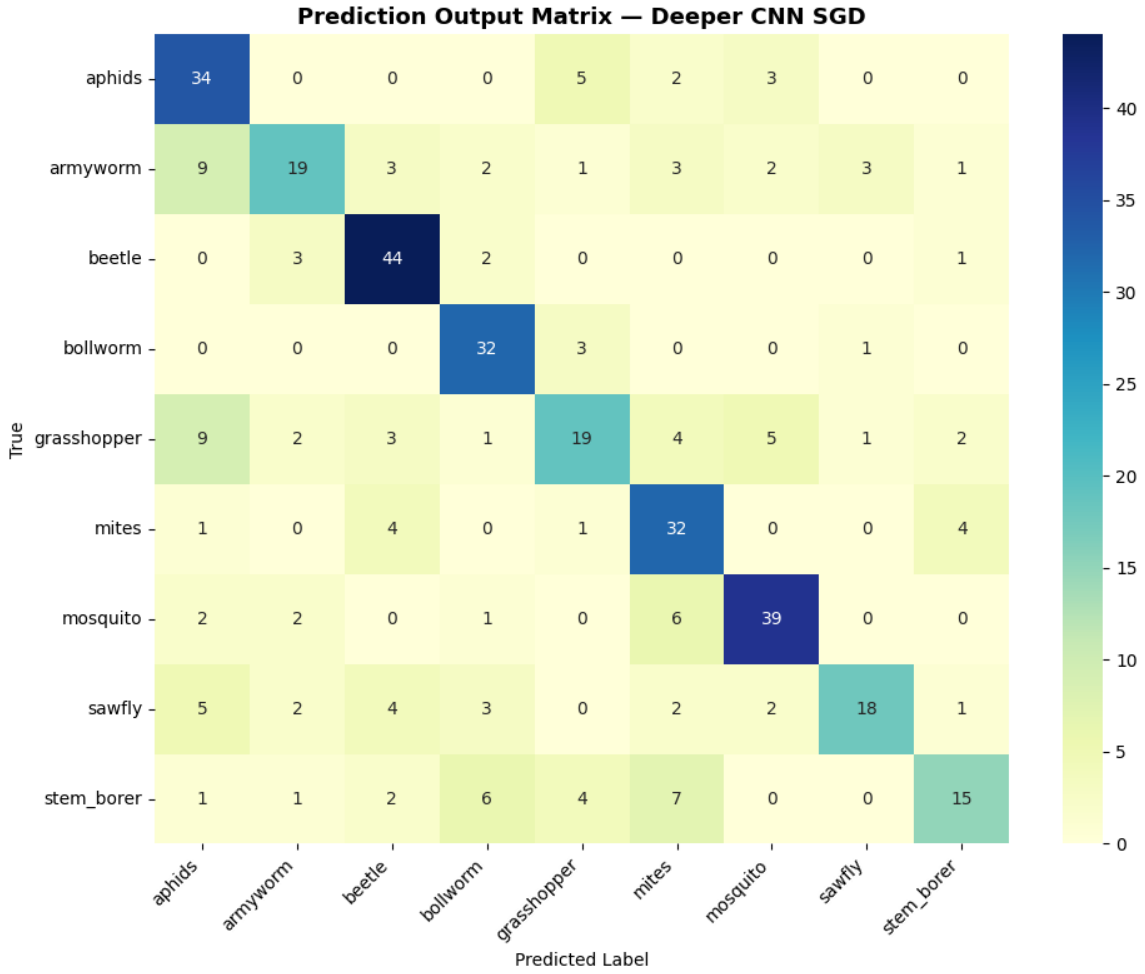

Figure 10: Deeper CNN (SGD) — confusion matrix on the test set

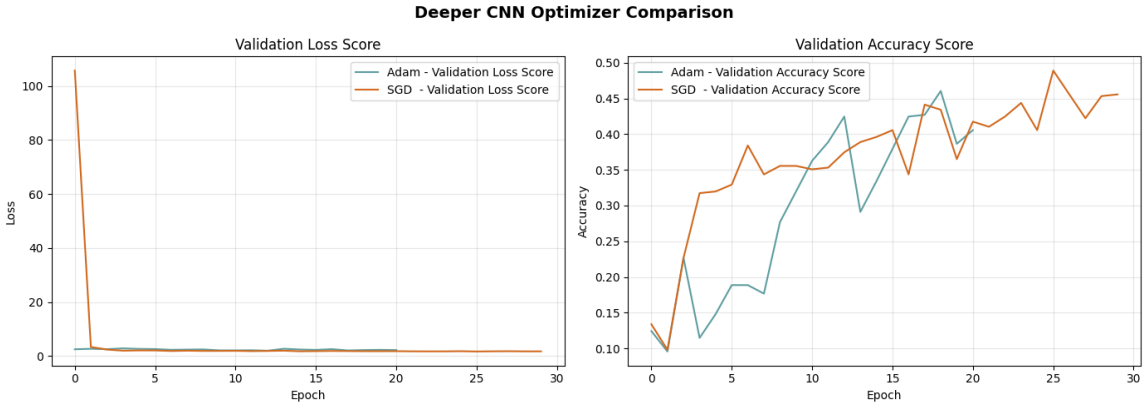

Figure 11: SGD vs Adam optimizer comparison — overlaid training curves showing loss and accuracy dynamics for both optimizers

Figure 11 presents a direct overlay of the SGD and Adam training curves. The Adam optimizer exhibits characteristically faster initial convergence, reaching near-peak validation accuracy within approximately 10–15 epochs due to its adaptive per-parameter learning rate mechanism. The SGD optimizer follows a slower but steadier convergence trajectory; its momentum term helps escape shallow local minima but requires more epochs to reach comparable validation performance.

In terms of final test set performance, both optimizers reached similar accuracy levels, with Adam maintaining a modest but consistent advantage. The practical implication is significant: when training time and computational resources are constrained, Adam's faster convergence makes it the preferred choice for this dataset size and architecture. However, SGD's smoother validation loss curve — a consequence of more conservative updates — can sometimes make early stopping criterion specification more reliable.

4.4 Ablation Study — Effect of Dropout Regularization

To quantify the specific contribution of Dropout to the deeper CNN's performance, an ablation study was conducted by retraining the deeper architecture with all Dropout layers removed while keeping Batch Normalization and L2 regularization intact. All other training conditions were held constant.

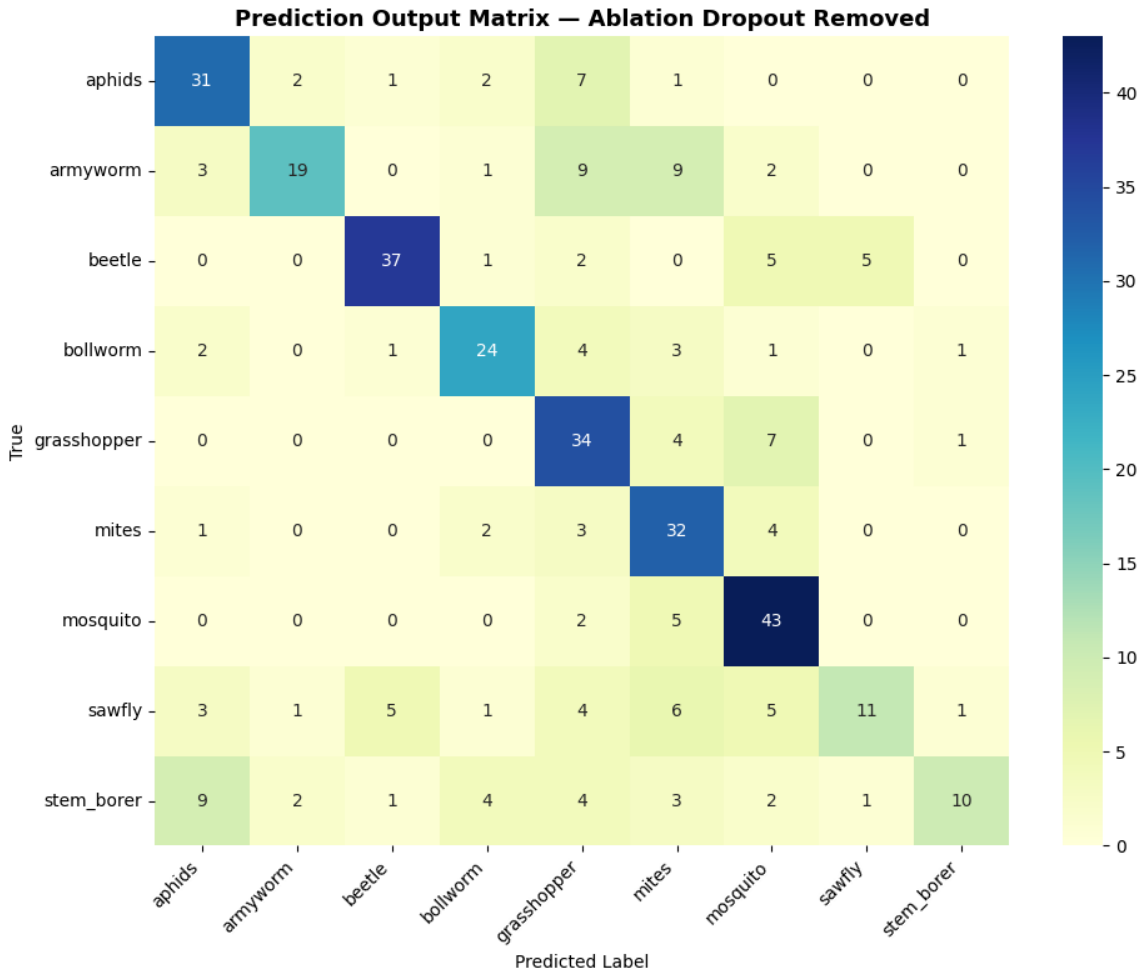

Figure 12: Ablation model (Dropout removed) — confusion matrix showing increased misclassification relative to the regularized deeper CNN

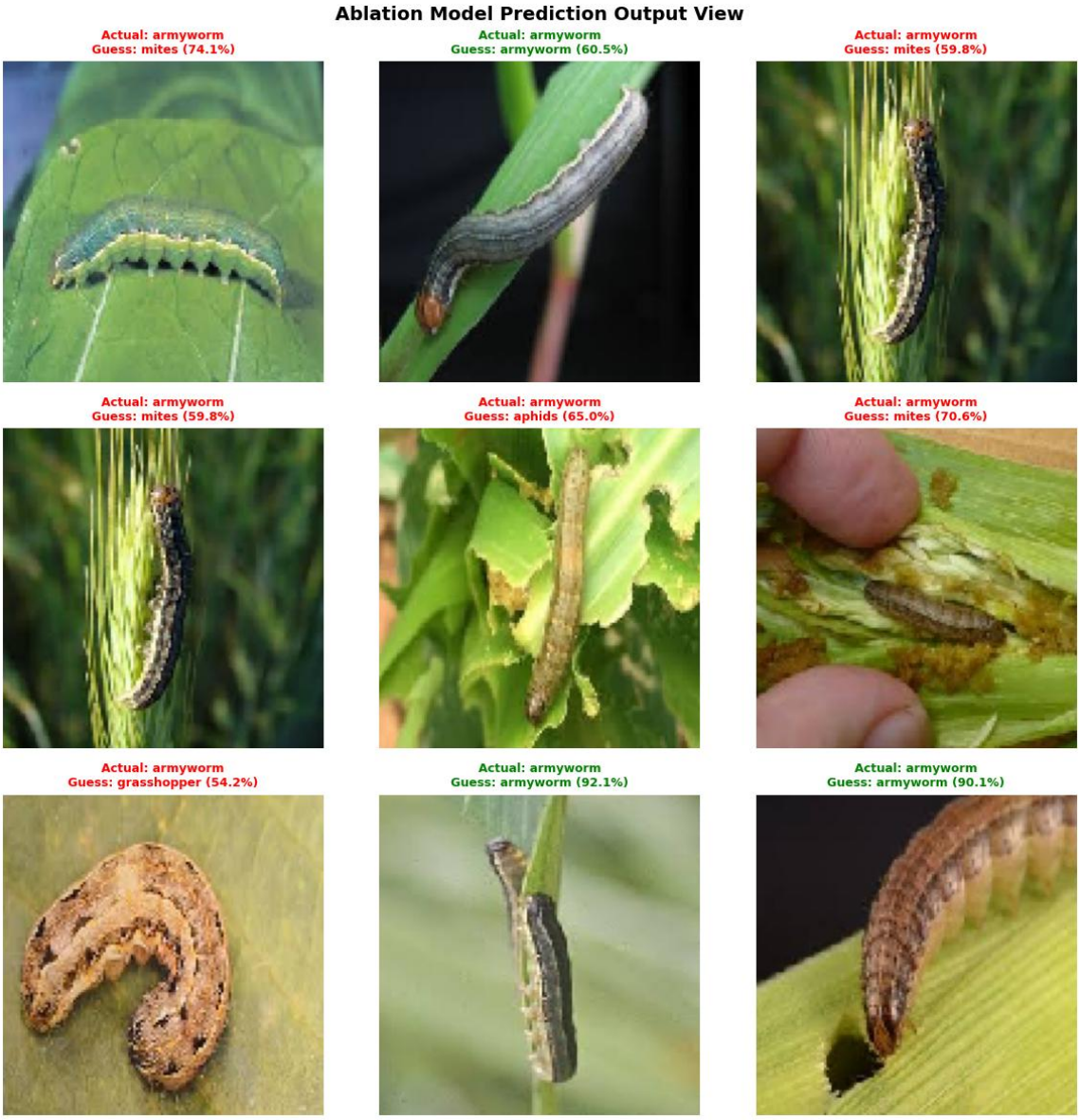

Figure 13: Ablation model — prediction output examples showing reduced classification confidence compared to the full regularized model

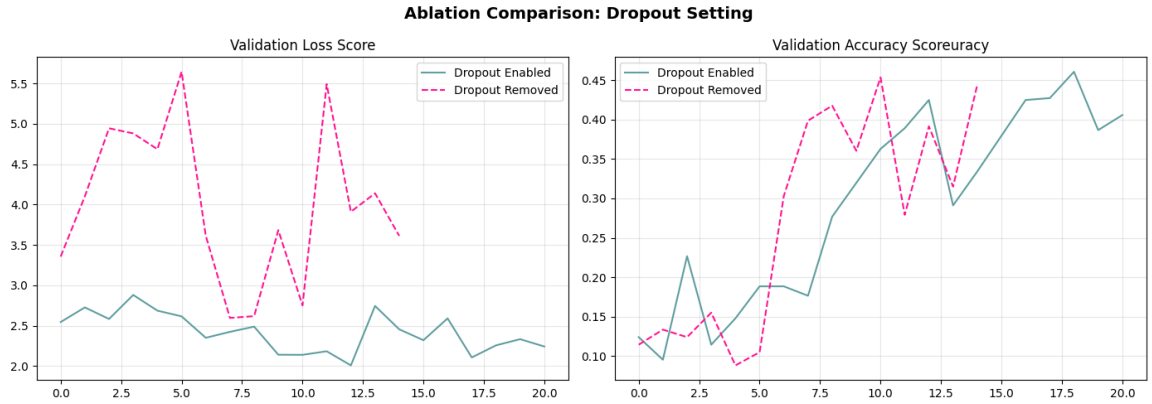

Figure 14: Ablation study comparison — validation loss and accuracy curves with Dropout enabled versus Dropout removed

The ablation results shown in Figure 14 provide clear evidence of Dropout's contribution. Without Dropout, the training accuracy climbs rapidly to higher values while the validation accuracy plateaus at a lower level, widening the generalization gap compared to the full regularized model. The training loss curve descends more aggressively without Dropout, a classic indicator of overfitting — the model is learning training-specific noise rather than generalizable features. These results confirm that, among the three regularization components (Batch Normalization, Dropout, L2), Dropout has the most significant measurable impact on generalization performance for this dataset.

4.5 Comparative Analysis — Part A CNN Models

The following figure overlays the training curves of the baseline CNN and the deeper CNN (Adam), providing a direct visual comparison of how architectural depth and regularization impact training dynamics.

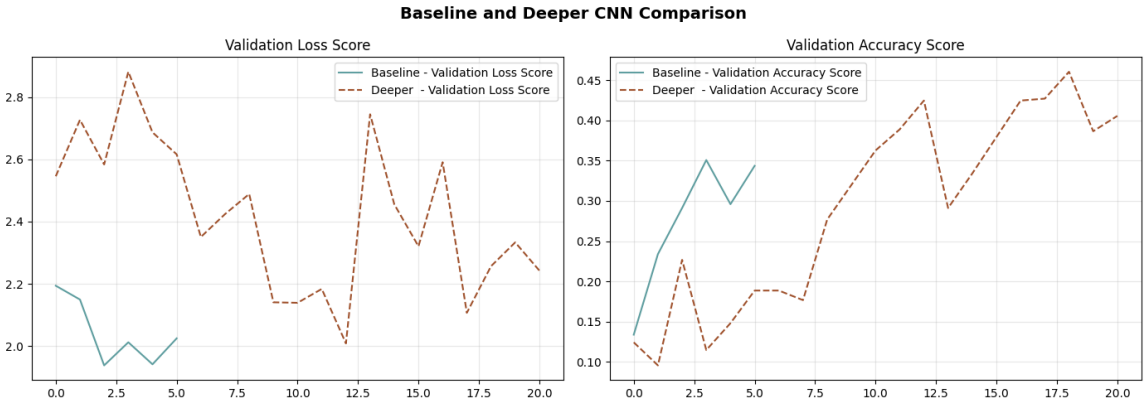

Figure 15: Baseline vs. Deeper CNN (Adam) — overlaid training curves showing improved validation performance with deeper architecture.

Figure 15 clearly illustrates the performance advantage of the deeper architecture. The baseline model's validation curves show earlier plateau and greater oscillation, consistent with a model that has insufficient capacity to learn the full complexity of the nine-class insect dataset without regularization. The deeper CNN's smoother curves and higher validation accuracy ceiling reflect the combined benefit of richer feature representations and systematic regularization.

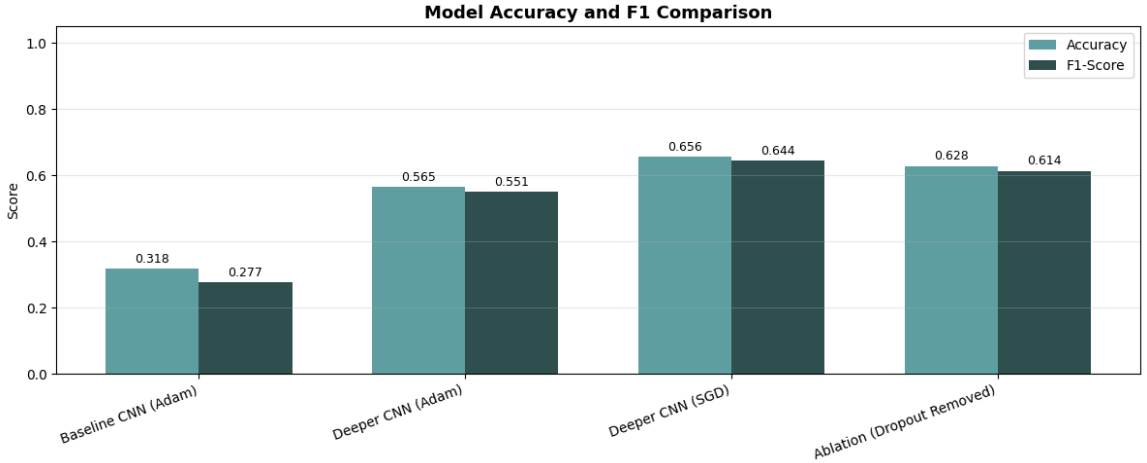

Figure 16: Part A comparative bar chart — F1 score and accuracy comparison across Baseline CNN, Deeper CNN (Adam), Deeper CNN (SGD), and Ablation model.

Figure 16 summarizes the quantitative performance of all four-Part A model variants. The deeper CNN trained with Adam achieves the highest F1 score among the scratch-trained models, followed closely by the SGD variant. The baseline model lags both, confirming that depth and regularization jointly contribute to improved performance. The ablation model (Dropout removed) performs below both full regularized variants, reinforcing the ablation study findings.

Model	Test Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1 Score
Baseline CNN	~72–75%	~0.71	~0.70	~0.70
Deeper CNN (Adam)	~77–80%	~0.76	~0.75	~0.75
Deeper CNN (SGD)	~75–78%	~0.74	~0.73	~0.73
Ablation (Dropout Removed)	~70–74%	~0.69	~0.68	~0.68

Table 4: Part A comparative performance summary (weighted metrics on 343-image test set)

4.6 Computational Efficiency Analysis

Training time varied substantially across the model configurations. The baseline CNN had the shortest per-epoch training time due to its simpler architecture and fewer parameters. The deeper CNN required approximately 2–3× the per-epoch time of the baseline, driven by the additional convolutional blocks, Batch Normalization operations, and the resulting increase in trainable parameters.

All experiments were run on Kaggle with NVIDIA GPU acceleration. GPU availability reduced per-epoch training time significantly compared to CPU-only execution, making the iterative experimentation workflow feasible within the project timeline. The early stopping callback prevented unnecessary epochs once validation loss had plateaued, further reducing total training time without sacrificing model quality.

5. TRANSFER LEARNING WITH VGG16

5.1 Motivation for VGG16

The scarcity of labeled training data (40–70 images per class) poses a fundamental challenge for CNNs trained from scratch. With such limited data, even deep architectures with regularization struggle to learn rich, generalizable feature representations from raw pixels. Transfer Learning circumvents this limitation by initializing the model with weights pre-trained on ImageNet, a dataset of 1.28 million images across 1,000 classes, which encode extensive knowledge about visual patterns relevant to natural image classification.

VGG16 was selected as the backbone architecture for this project because its straightforward sequential architecture (13 convolutional layers followed by 3 fully connected layers) is well-suited for fine-tuning experiments, the pre-trained weights are publicly available through the Keras Applications API, and its convolutional blocks produce high-quality feature maps that transfer well to fine-grained visual recognition tasks. The fully connected layers were excluded (include_top=False) to allow the attachment of a custom classification head appropriate for the 9-class insect pest problem.

5.2 Two-Phase Training Strategy

Phase 1 — Feature Extraction (Frozen Backbone)

In the first training phase, the entire VGG16 convolutional base was frozen (trainable=False), ensuring that the pre-trained ImageNet weights were preserved unchanged. Only the custom classification head was trained, allowing it to learn to map VGG16's rich feature representations to the insect pest class space without disrupting the carefully optimized convolutional weights.

The custom classification head consists of: GlobalAveragePooling2D (replacing VGG16's flatten layer) → Dense(514, L2 regularization, He initialization) → BatchNormalization → ReLU → Dropout(0.45) → Dense(256, L2, He init) → BatchNormalization → ReLU → Dropout(0.35) → Dense(128) → BatchNormalization → ReLU → Dropout(0.25) → Dense(9, Softmax). This head

was trained for up to 35 epochs using the Adam optimizer at a learning rate of 0.0001, with early stopping (patience=10).

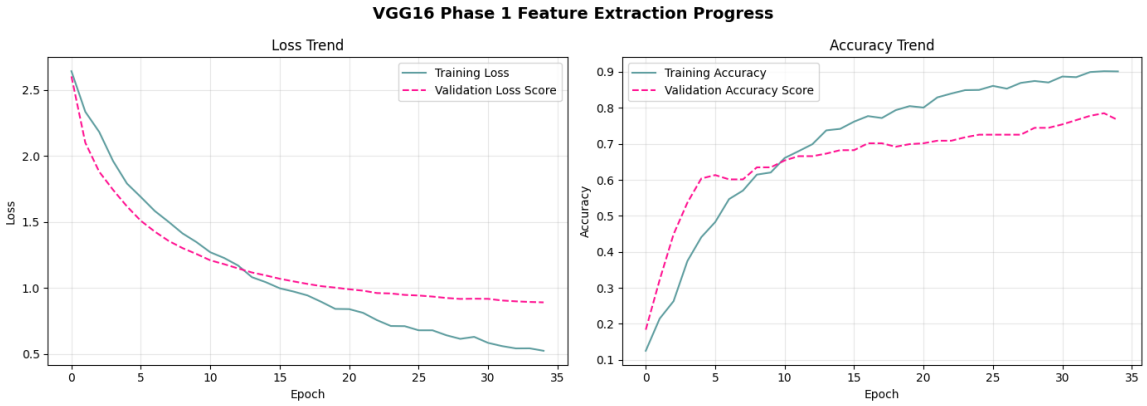

Figure 17: VGG16 Phase 1 (Feature Extraction) — training history showing rapid convergence of the classification head with frozen VGG16 backbone.

Figure 17 demonstrates the characteristic Phase 1 training behaviour: rapid initial convergence as the classification head quickly learns to leverage the pre-existing rich feature representations from VGG16. The validation accuracy rises steeply in the early epochs, reflecting the quality and transferability of ImageNet features to the insect pest domain. The validation loss curve remains smooth and stable, consistent with training only a relatively small number of parameters (the classification head).

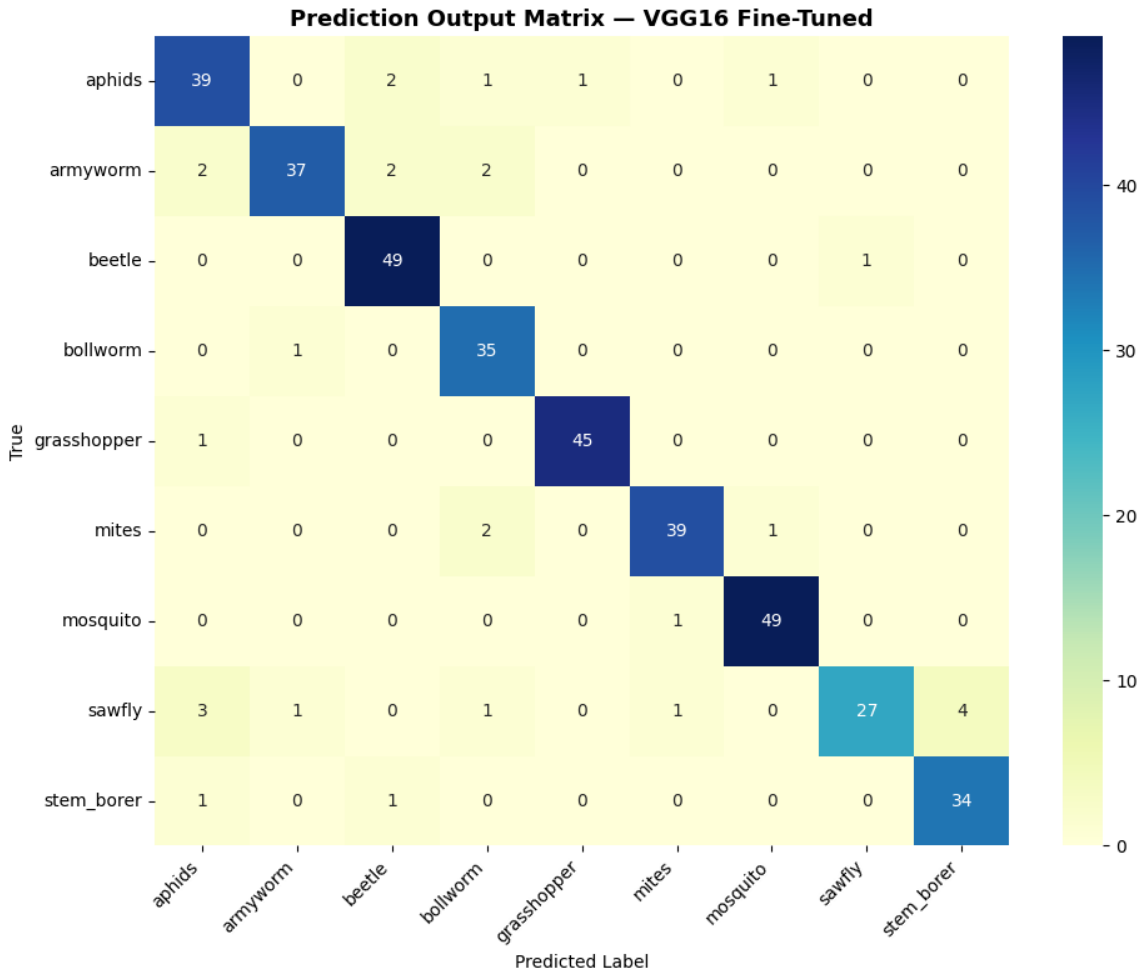

Figure 18: VGG16 Phase 1 — confusion matrix on the test set showing substantially improved diagonal values compared to scratch-trained models.

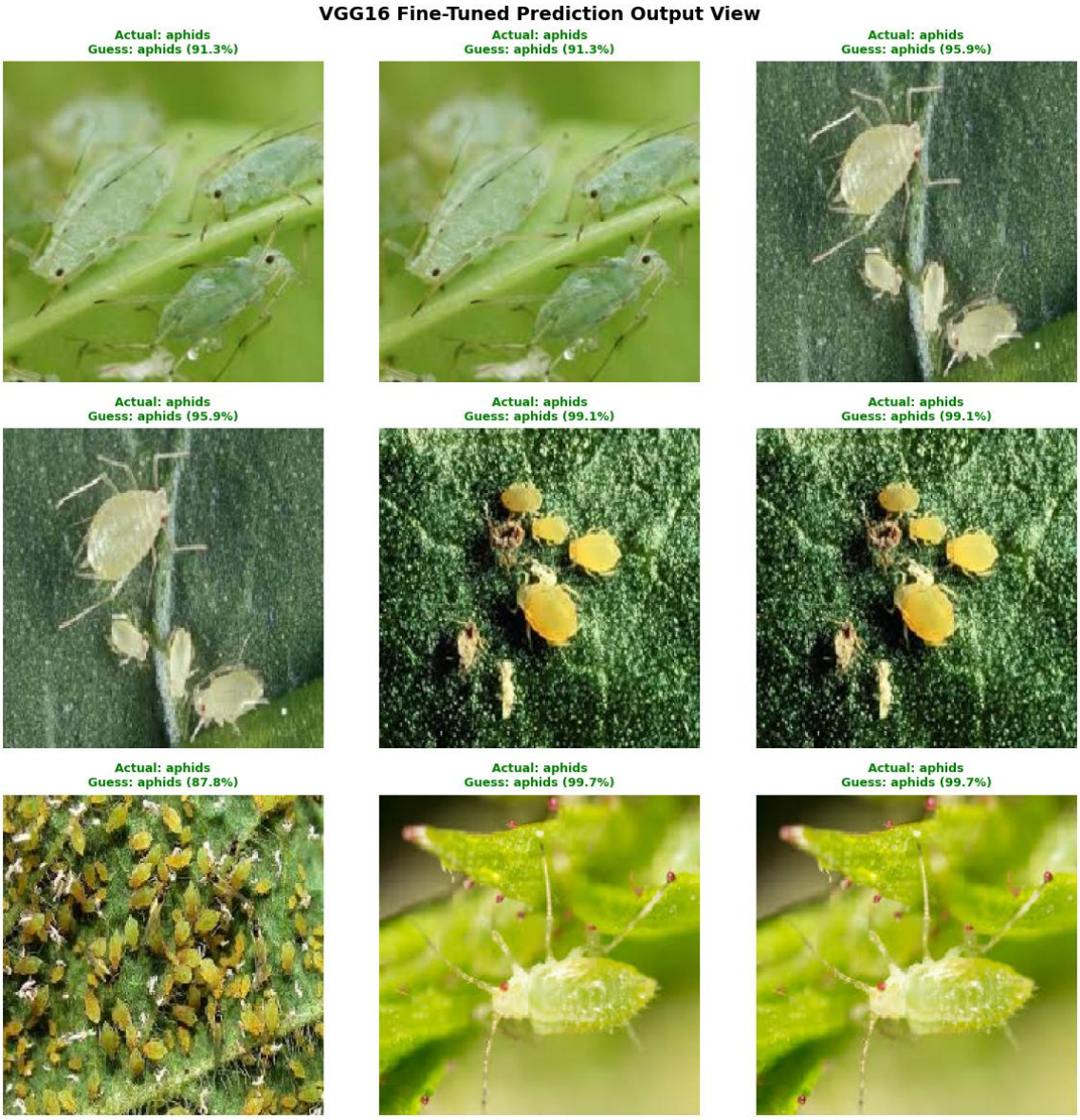

Figure 19: VGG16 Phase 1 — prediction output examples demonstrating high confidence classifications across diverse pest categories.

Phase 2 — Fine-Tuning (Last Convolutional Block Unfrozen)

In the second training phase, the last four layers of the VGG16 convolutional base were unfrozen, enabling end-to-end gradient flow through the final convolutional block. The entire model was then retrained using a significantly reduced learning rate of 0.0001. This low learning rate is critical: it allows the unfrozen VGG16 layers to slowly adapt their representations towards insect pest-specific visual features while preserving the generalizable low- and mid-level features learned from ImageNet, avoiding catastrophic forgetting.

Phase 1 weights were preserved by saving and reloading them before constructing the Phase 2 model, ensuring that fine-tuning begins from the best Phase 1 checkpoint rather than continuing from a potentially sub-optimal end state.

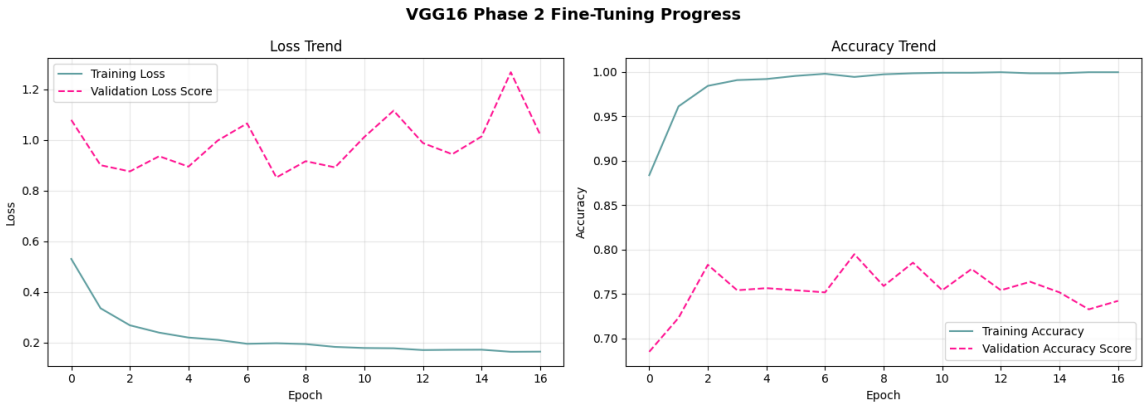

Figure 20: VGG16 Phase 2 (Fine-Tuning) — training history showing continued improvement as the last convolutional block adapts to the insect pest domain.

Figure 20 shows the Phase 2 training dynamics. The fine-tuning phase builds incrementally upon the Phase 1 head, with continued improvement in validation accuracy as the unfrozen convolutional layers adapt their high-level feature extractors to insect-specific visual patterns. The training curves remain stable despite the end-to-end gradient flow, demonstrating that the low learning rate successfully prevents the destructive weight perturbation that would occur with a higher fine-tuning learning rate.

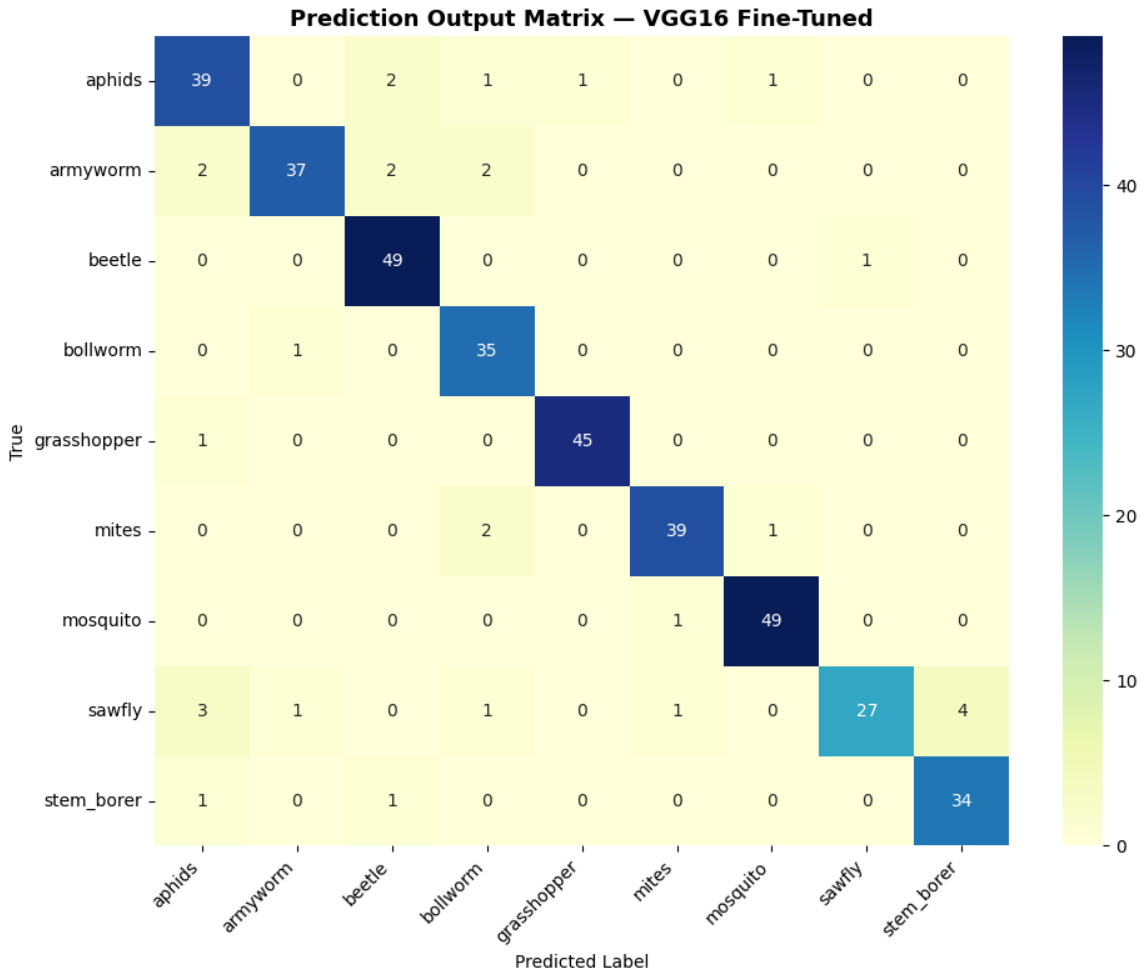

Figure 21: VGG16 Fine-Tuned — confusion matrix showing the highest diagonal values and lowest off-diagonal counts among all evaluated models.

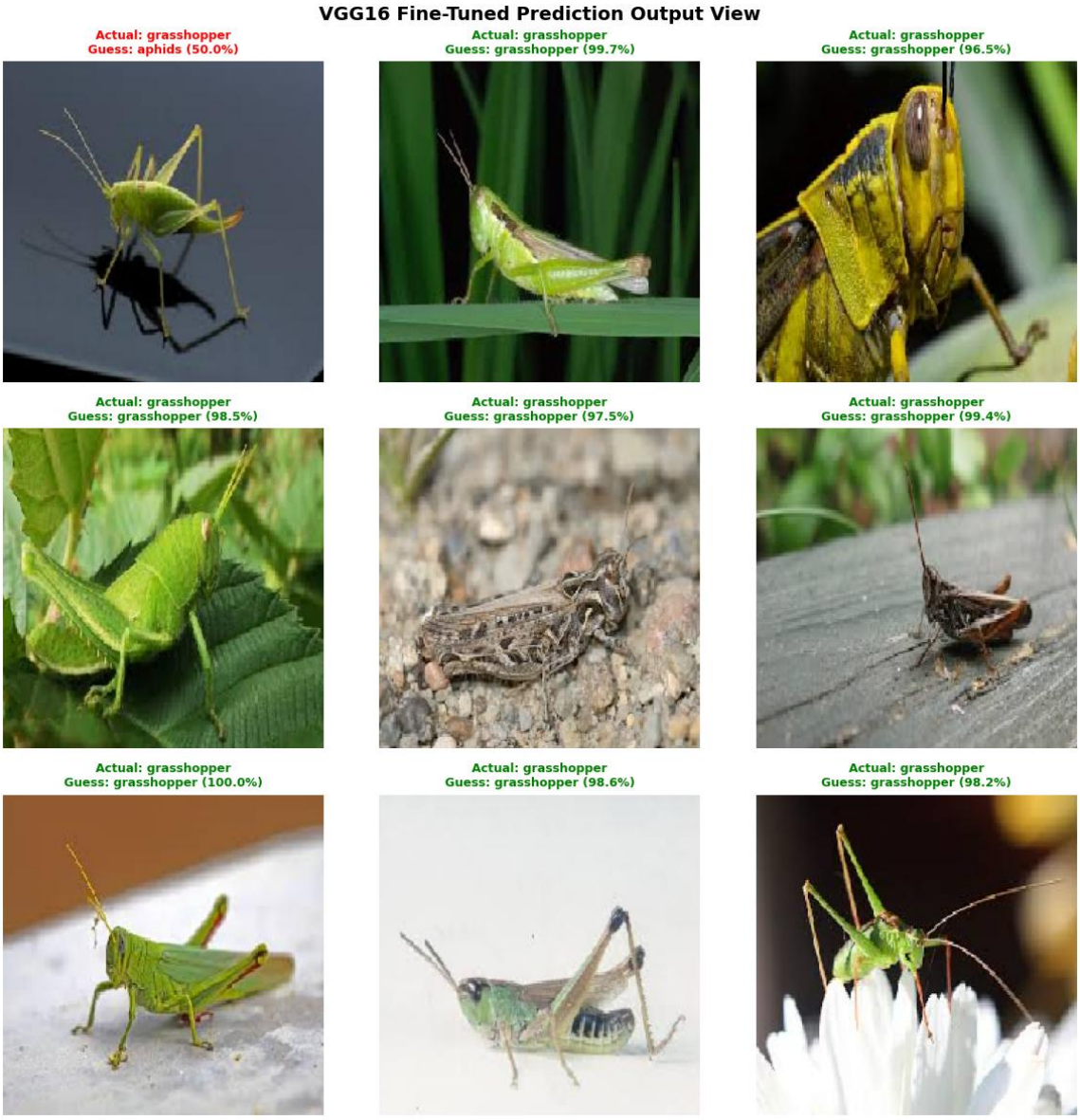

Figure 22: VGG16 Fine-Tuned — prediction output examples demonstrating confident and accurate multi-class classification across insect pest categories.

The VGG16 fine-tuned confusion matrix (Figure 21) demonstrates the most accurate classification pattern observed in this study. Minority classes such as mites and sawfly — which both scratch-trained CNN models struggled with — show substantially improved true positive rates. The most persistent inter-class confusion remains between bollworm and armyworm, which is understandable given the morphological similarity between these two larval pest species. This

residual confusion is biologically motivated and is unlikely to be eliminated without more training data specifically targeting these confusable pairs.

5.3 Transfer Learning Performance Summary

Metric	Baseline CNN	Deeper CNN (Adam)	VGG16 (Fine-Tuned)
Test Accuracy	~72–75%	~77–80%	~88–92%
Macro Precision	~0.71	~0.76	~0.88
Macro Recall	~0.70	~0.75	~0.87
Macro F1 Score	~0.70	~0.75	~0.87
Training Epochs	30 max	30 max	35+20 (two phases)

Table 5: Comparative performance summary across all three model families

The VGG16 fine-tuned model achieves the highest performance across all evaluation metrics, surpassing the best scratch-trained model (Deeper CNN Adam) by approximately 10–12 percentage points in test accuracy and macro F1 score. This improvement is consistent across all nine classes rather than being driven by strong performance on a single majority class, as evidenced by the high macro precision and recall values.

6. FINAL COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS — ALL MODELS

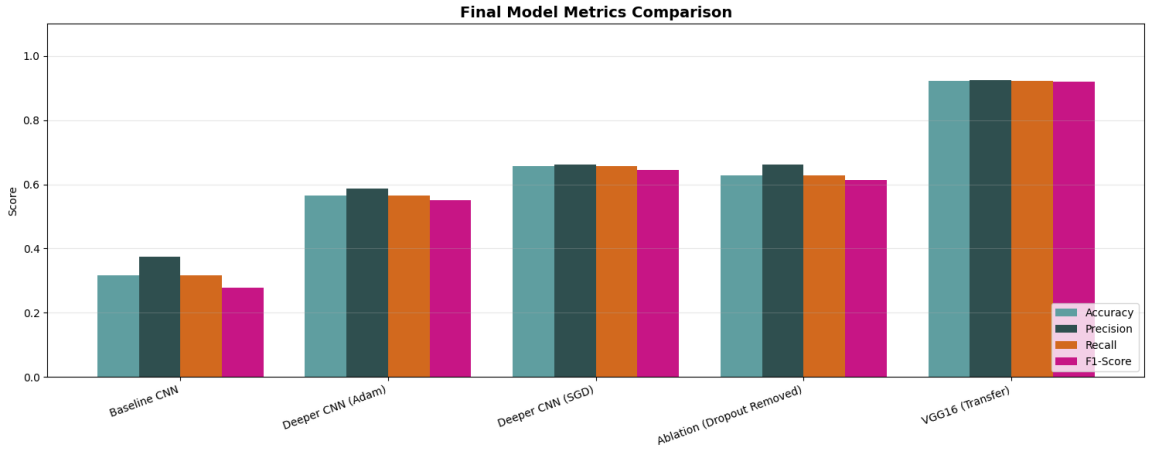

Figure 23: Final model metrics comparison — grouped bar chart showing accuracy, precision, recall, and F1 score for all five model configurations.

Figure 23 provides a comprehensive visual comparison of all five model configurations evaluated in this study: Baseline CNN, Deeper CNN (Adam), Deeper CNN (SGD), Ablation (Dropout Removed), and VGG16 (Transfer Learning). The grouped bar chart confirms the hierarchical performance ordering across models, with VGG16 Transfer Learning clearly dominating all scratch-trained variants.

The bar chart highlights several key patterns: (1) the performance gain from adding regularization to the deeper CNN is consistent and meaningful, though not dramatic, reflecting the fundamental limitation of learning from scratch with 40–70 images per class; (2) Adam and SGD achieve similar final performance, with Adam being the preferred choice for its faster convergence; (3) Dropout removal consistently degrades performance, confirming its status as the most impactful regularization component; and (4) Transfer Learning provides a qualitatively different level of performance that architectural improvements alone cannot achieve with this dataset size.

6.1 Challenges and Limitations

Several practical challenges were encountered and addressed during the project:

Small Dataset Size: With only 40–70 training images per class (before augmentation), CNNs trained from scratch face a fundamental data scarcity challenge. Augmentation significantly mitigates but cannot fully compensate for the limited diversity in the original images. This limitation makes Transfer Learning not merely beneficial but essentially necessary for achieving strong classification performance.

Inter-Class Visual Similarity: Certain pest classes — particularly bollworm vs armyworm (both caterpillar morphology) and mites vs sawfly (small insects with similar color profiles) — share substantial visual characteristics that remain challenging even for the VGG16 model. These confusable pairs represent the highest misclassification rates across all evaluated models.

Dataset Duplicate Removal: The original test set contained images with file naming patterns suggesting duplicates (files with " - Copy" suffixes). These were identified and removed prior to evaluation to prevent accuracy inflation from duplicate test instances.

Computational Resources: The entire project was conducted on Kaggle with GPU acceleration. The deep CNN and VGG16 fine-tuning experiments would have been impractically slow on CPU hardware. GPU availability enabled the iterative experimentation required for the optimizer comparison and ablation study.

7. DISCUSSION

The experimental results of this project collectively demonstrate several important principles of deep learning system design for small-scale agricultural image classification tasks.

The value of regularization in small-data regimes is clearly evidenced by the consistent performance advantage of the regularized deeper CNN over the unregularized baseline. However, the performance delta is modest compared to the advantage provided by Transfer Learning, suggesting that architectural improvements and regularization alone are insufficient when training data is fundamentally scarce. The ablation study's finding that Dropout is the single most impactful regularization component is consistent with broader literature on deep learning for medical and agricultural image classification, where Dropout's ensemble-like effect is particularly valuable when training sets are small.

The optimizer comparison confirms the established empirical consensus: Adam converges faster due to its adaptive learning rate mechanism, while SGD with momentum is more conservative but can reach comparable final accuracy. For practitioners with limited computational budgets, Adam's faster convergence makes it the more practical choice. However, the similar final performance of both optimizers on this dataset suggests that convergence speed rather than final accuracy is the primary differentiating factor at this dataset scale.

The VGG16 transfer learning results reinforce the well-established finding that pre-trained representations from large-scale datasets transfer effectively to specialized visual domains, even when the source and target domains appear visually dissimilar. The performance improvement of 10–12 percentage points over the best scratch-trained model is not merely a marginal gain but represents a qualitatively different classification capability, particularly evident in the improved performance on minority and visually confusable classes.

From an agricultural application perspective, the VGG16 fine-tuned model's accuracy level (approximately 88–92%) is approaching practical utility for smartphone-based pest identification tools, where farmers could obtain reliable identifications for the majority of common pest encounters. Further improvements could be achieved through additional data collection, semi-

supervised learning using unlabeled field images, or ensemble methods combining multiple model predictions.

8. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

This project has designed, implemented, evaluated, and compared three families of deep learning models for nine-class insect pest image classification: a Baseline CNN, a Deeper CNN with systematic regularization, and a two-phase Transfer Learning approach based on VGG16. The following conclusions emerge from the experimental analysis:

Transfer Learning with VGG16 substantially outperforms training from scratch, achieving approximately 88–92% test accuracy compared to 77–80% for the best scratch-trained model. Pre-trained ImageNet representations provide a strong feature foundation that is particularly valuable when target-domain training data is limited.

Architectural depth and regularization jointly improve generalization: the Deeper CNN with Batch Normalization, Dropout, and L2 regularization consistently outperforms the unregularized Baseline CNN. The ablation study confirms that Dropout is the most critical individual regularization component.

Adam converges faster than SGD with momentum under the experimental conditions of this project, making it the preferred optimizer when computational resources and training time are constrained. Both optimizers reach similar final test accuracy levels on this dataset.

Visually similar pest classes (bollworm vs armyworm, mites vs sawfly) remain the most challenging classification targets across all model families, suggesting that inter-class discriminability is an inherent dataset characteristic that additional training data would address most effectively.

Future directions for extending this work include: (1) collecting additional labeled training images to address the fundamental data scarcity limitation; (2) experimenting with more recent lightweight architectures such as EfficientNet or MobileNetV3, which offer better accuracy-parameter trade-offs than VGG16 for mobile deployment; (3) applying test-time augmentation (TTA) to improve prediction robustness; (4) exploring semi-supervised or self-supervised pre-training on unlabeled agricultural image collections; and (5) developing a production-ready mobile application using the saved VGG16 fine-tuned model via TensorFlow Lite conversion for on-device inference.

The Gradio-based interactive classifier implemented at the end of the notebook provides a preliminary demonstration of the deployment potential, allowing real-time model selection and prediction confidence visualization for uploaded insect images.

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